

AN INTERVIEW WITH ALFRED C. SNIDER

Delainey LaHood-Burns

Alfred C. “Tuna” Snider, the former Edwin W. Lawrence Professor of Forensics at the University of Vermont and director of the World Debate Institute, was an internationally acclaimed debate coach, scholar, and author known for changing the lives of citizens around the globe through critical communication and debate. Despite the numerous awards and recognitions he received for his work, those who knew Tuna best can attest that he held little regard for status and decorations. Instead he measured his success through the transformation he saw in his students, and was driven by the positive change he felt debate could create in the world.

During the summer of 2015, Professor Snider was kind enough to grant me an interview about his life and work for Big Heavy World, one of Burlington’s local community-based radio stations. We recorded the interview in his office in late August. With the summer winding down and a new debate season approaching, I was struck by how optimistic and energetic Tuna was. As we talked, he commented,

I see some of my colleagues at many schools counting down their days for retirement and I just can’t imagine that. I just don’t want retirement to come. I’m having so much fun. I have opportunities now I didn’t have twenty years ago. So, you know, I need to- I want to take advantage of it.

With his passing, it’s impossible not to think back on those words and feel the lingering sentiment that he had so much left to give. But it is also important to recognize how much there is to celebrate about

his life and scholarship. By continuing to recognize his contributions to academic Speech, Debate, and Communication Studies we carry on the work that defined Professor Snider's life. It is my hope that through this interview, and the other works found in this collection, we can continue to learn from Professor Snider, whose legacy carries on for us as long as we celebrate and contribute to the change he inspired.

On his approach to life during and after his studies at Brown University:

AS: I was not a particularly diligent student at the University. I was having a good time, I was debating a lot, and I was politically active. So, you know, I wanted to stay in school so I could keep doing those other things.¹

I knew I wanted to coach debate. I knew that. I didn't know how or what. I made a really conscious decision to do what made me happy. Not status, not money, but to do what makes me happy. And that was not quite as easy as it sounds. Because you have to say: "What about my task environment will make me happy?" But, and also, I wanted to pay the rent and have some long-term security. So I thought that being a University Professor really did that.

But, you know, you need to figure out how to thrive, not just survive, but thrive. Think about what it is that makes you happy, what is it that society says should make you happy, and there's a huge disconnect between what actually makes you happy and what society says you need to be happy. One of the things I say is that, "Yeah, you need to pay the rent. Yeah, you're going to have to have a job. But you want it to be something you

¹ In transcribing this interview I've chosen to maintain as much of the original quotations as possible, while making minimal edits for readability.

enjoy, you want it to be something that's productive, and you don't want to serve the war machine." And so if you can make those three, that's good.

DLB: Did you ever find yourself at a point where you did feel like you were pursuing the wrong thing, like money and status?

AS: I've been accused of being guilty of shameless self-promotion. And the reason for this is on the Internet I'm very present. And if you're interested in debate anywhere, and if you look around about debate, start Googling debate, you're going to find me, and my works and websites and videos and everything. And I think I realized quite early, in the early nineties, the value of the Internet and how it was going to change everything. And so I thought, "I want to be there so people can reach out to me and create networks." I can't fly everywhere and meet everywhere, but I can, through the Internet, reach a lot of people. So that has worked well for me.

The reason I'm involved with this project in Palestine is that they got a debate grant and they didn't know what to do with it. So they looked around and found me. And now it's become quite a success and I'm really happy with it and the kids are great. And I really feel if any students, if any young people in the world, need to learn how to speak truth to power, it's Palestinian youth. And clearly, throwing rocks at Israeli soldiers is not working. There has to be a better way for them to state their case and make their argument. And they're really excited about it. They're motivated, they're high-achievers, they're optimistic, and it's great.

DLB: Where do you think that comes from for them? Is it part of the culture that they're positive?

AS: I think not. In fact, there's a lot of pessimism

in Palestinian society. That “Oh, we can’t fix this, it’s never going to change,” and so on. I think that as youth, they have some optimism. And also they have rage. Rage at how they’re treated, rage at how they’re communities are marginalized, rage about their land being stolen, and rage about everyday humiliations that they experience. And I’m like look, “Let’s re-channel this rage. Let’s re-channel it in a productive way. Let’s make the case for the world about what’s going on and about the true nature of Palestinian people.” You just teach people how to think for themselves and make arguments and state their case, they’ll take care of it. They’ll take care of it.

Almost everywhere I go the governments are not too good, and the adults are okay, and the young people are great. That’s my sort of generalization. And, you know, it’s quite different, and yet the people have dignity and humor and they were cool. It’s a cultural experience, right? I got to see something I hadn’t really seen before.

On student success:

AS: My vision is it’s not how high they rise, but how far they come. So if you come from a lower position and get so much better, that’s actually more important than if you’re already high and get a little higher.

And ultimately it’s about what will change your life. It’s how will you transform your future? And I think there’s a magical moment of transformation when people find their voice. This is an expression I use for when you go, “Hey I have something to say, people might want to hear what I have to say, and I can say it okay. Wow, I don’t need to be quiet anymore. I don’t need to be passive. I can be a change agent.” And I think as long as that happens, I’m excited.

DLB: Do you remember having that experience?

AS: When I was very young I had a serious stuttering problem, very serious. And I tried not to talk because everybody would laugh at me and make fun of me. And in early school they tested your reading ability by having you read out loud and I couldn’t read out loud. So I read pretty well, but I was in the stupidest reading group. So I just sort of kept quiet.

And my parents eventually got me some speech therapy, and I got over my stuttering, and then I couldn’t shut up. That was a problem, because in school you’re supposed to shut up and listen. And I just couldn’t shut up. So I was a discipline problem, I was difficult. It was not until that very first moment I was in a debate and I talked about what I wanted to talk about and people listened and I said, “Okay, this is the way it ought to be.” And that completely transformed how I approached school. It changed me from being a very subpar student to being an excellent student. It really did everything for me.

On student failure:

AS: There are traits that bother me and they’re not uniquely held by young people. They’re also found in society and they bother me. And one of which is this notion that thinking is work. Work’s bad, thinking is work, therefore I don’t want to do it. Whereas thinking is life, that’s what it means to be human is to think. You know you want to be a leader, you want to be looked up to, you want to have ideas that are useful. So this ‘go along to get along,’ thing, I can’t stand it.

DLB: For debate you have to stay up-to-date with current world politics and events. With your schedule how do you find time to keep up?

AS: Well I have the news on in the background quite

often. But I haven't had television in my house for the last fifteen years because I felt that it was destructive to learning. So now I have news on in the background while I'm working and I spend time everyday reading. I spend at least an hour and a half or two hours every day reading news stories. And I've developed a webpage called news for debaters, which has links to a lot of different press outlets that I like. And they're about topics, and there are some that are just regional like Latin America, Southeast Asia. So it's really a new way, a very 21st century way, of doing news. So I don't want to rely on anyone for my information. I need diversity so I can make my own mind up.

DLB: Why do you think television is destructive to learning?

AS: I think commercials are a huge waste of time. I think they brainwash you to believe you need these things to be happy, whereas you don't need these things to be happy. And they will not make you happy. It burns your time, time gets passed, but nothing good comes from it. And time is the most important thing we have. You know, money comes and goes. Time just goes. And so how you spend your time is so important. And now that I'm not watching television I'm reading more. I'm listening to music, which I find incredibly stimulating, working on projects, reading the news. I'm much more productive.

DLB: As your career developed, what are some accomplishments that have really made you happy? And are there any that you thought would make you happy, but didn't?

AS: Major competitive tournament victories feel really good, but then the next day you're still you, you still have the challenges in front of you. So that's, you

know, I mean competition is good, it motivates people, it focuses them. But it's a little emptier than you might think.

Things that have made me happy, well, there are an infinite number of things that make me happy, but one of which is when I took this job I saw an incredible debate program with great history that was totally in the dumps. But in the fifties and sixties this was where it was at, UVM was top-notch, and then they kind of declined. And I said, "This is such a great infrastructure to work with." Our endowment, that we have secured funding, that my professorship is secured and always has to be linked to the debate team.

And Robert Huber, who was the debate coach for a long time before I got here, and he sort of watched as people failed to replace him, told me, he said, "Don't think your personality is going to influence anything after you're gone. Right? You have to build an institution that's going to last."

And I think we've really done that. We've expanded our endowment, we've expanded our academic reach, we've got a global reputation now that we didn't have. And I think we have a much better alumni base to support us. And so I think the debate program now is more secure then it was when I arrived. And that's something that I had as a goal, and was very, very important to me.

Professor Alfred Charles Snider passed away in December of 2015 at the age of 65. He was known for his humor, sharp wit, and the love he poured into his work and the students he taught. As a prominent leader and coach his influence was felt on a global scale, and he worked tirelessly around the world to "fight back the darkness" by giving people the gift of speech and debate.

Delainey LaHood-Burns is a graduate of the University of Vermont where Professor Alfred Snider served as her coach and mentor. After graduation she worked for Big Heavy World, a non-profit radio station based in Burlington, Vermont, interviewing local leaders and innovators working to advance their communities. She currently is a secondary school teacher and athletic youth coach in Ottawa, Ontario, and is preparing to pursue a Masters in Communications with an emphasis on health and science.

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